Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (2025)

I. Unified Governance & GPF Edition

USA Pickleball serves as the National Governing Body for the sport in the United States, maintaining the official rules to preserve its traditional nature and character [cite: 1, 2]. The 2025 edition is notably presented as the 'Global Pickleball Federation (GPF) Edition,' reflecting a commitment to international growth and standardization across all partner continental federations [cite: 2]. The mission remains the same: to perpetuate the growth and advancement of the sport while ensuring consistent rules for recreational, social, and sanctioned tournament play [cite: 1, 2].

II. Court and Equipment Standards

The standard court size remains 20 feet wide by 44 feet long ($6.10m \times 13.41m$) for both singles and doubles play [cite: 1, 2]. The net height is specified at 36 inches at the sidelines and 34 inches at the center [cite: 1, 2]. The 7-foot Non-Volley Zone (NVZ) continues to be the primary court feature preventing aggressive play directly at the net [cite: 1, 2]. Paddle standards emphasize rigid, non-compressible materials, and the ball must be a hollow plastic sphere with 26 to 40 circular holes [cite: 1, 2].

III. Service Mechanics: Consistency and Control

Traditional Volley Serve

The volley serve must be hit with an underhand motion, with the paddle contacting the ball below the waist [cite: 1, 2]. The server's arm must move in an upward arc, and the highest point of the paddle head must be below the wrist at the point of impact [cite: 1, 2].

Drop Serve & Release Rules

The 2025 rules reinforce that the ball must be released from the hand in a natural manner without any added spin, force, or manipulation [cite: 1, 2]. In the drop serve, the ball must be dropped and allowed to bounce naturally; it cannot be thrown downward or tossed upward to gain momentum [cite: 1, 2].

IV. Gameplay and Scoring Dynamics

Standard play continues to use 'side-out' scoring, where only the serving team can earn points [cite: 1, 2]. Matches are generally played to 11 points, winning by a margin of 2 [cite: 1, 2]. The Two-Bounce Rule remains a cornerstone: the ball must bounce once on each side

before any volleying can occur [cite: 1, 2]. Faults include hitting the ball out of bounds, failing to clear the NVZ on a serve, or touching the NVZ during or after a volley due to momentum [cite: 1, 2].

V. Professionalism and Fair Play

The 2025 rules highlight the importance of player conduct and the integrity of the game [cite: 1, 2]. Players are responsible for making accurate line calls and showing respect to opponents and officials [cite: 1, 2]. Technical fouls may be issued for abusive language, intentional delays, or paddle abuse, reflecting a zero-tolerance policy for unsportsmanlike behavior in sanctioned play [cite: 1, 2].